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Entrepreneurship enhancement policies and the competitiveness web: The case of the European South

Vlados Charis[1], Koutroukis Theodore[2], Chatzinikolaou Dimos[3], & Demertzis Michail[4]

Abstract

This chapter aims to conceptualize the general framework of policies to support entrepreneurship and competitiveness by indicating a move from a dispersive comprehension of competitiveness towards an integrated macro-meso-micro perspective, by taking as a case study the European South. First, it presents theoretical contributions to entrepreneurship enhancement policies, which mostly suggest that intervention can be effective in a fragmentary and relatively incoherent way. Then, it counter-proposes the "competitiveness web" approach, which gives an integrated policy framework for the competitive strengthening and evolution of a socioeconomic system. In the framework of competitiveness web, we analyze and propose a meso-micro level policy via the Institutes of Local Development and Innovation (ILDI), which is a policy for empowering the local and regional business ecosystems through the enhancement of business innovation. Finally, by using the competitiveness web filter, we propose the structuration of a mechanism that could identify the level at which the socioeconomic entities in different spatial levels can articulate their policies for entrepreneurship enhancement in the macro-meso-micro integrated approach.

Keywords: Entrepreneurship enhancement policies, Competitiveness Web, Institutes of Local Development and Innovation (ILDI), Macro-meso-micro analysis, European South

Introduction

The role of entrepreneurship in the current phase of crisis and restructuring of globalization is critical to the competitiveness of all socioeconomic systems, whether at local, national, or international level. From an evolutionary perspective, the innovative action of the firms transforms the hosting socioeconomic systems in their structural elements since the introduction of any innovation disrupts the preexisting equilibrium (Vlados, Deniozos and Chatzinikolaou, 2018; Vlados, Deniozos, Chatzinikolaou and Demertzis, 2018). In broad terms and from a neo-Schumpeterian perspective (Pacheco, Manhães and Maldonado, 2017), the contemporary phase of the crisis of globalization reveals that capitalism is still an ongoing phenomenon of creative destruction at all levels (economic, social, political, cultural and ideological).

This restructuring of globalization means that the previous regime of relative balance is heading towards the exhaustion of its developmental limits progressively and that a new, sustainable and totalizing model on a global scale is required. From the perspective of the French School of Regulation, which debated mostly the development of nation-centered socioeconomic systems, the qualitative and quantitative accumulation regime of globalization is incapable of sustaining further socioeconomic progress and, therefore, the world economy goes through a transitory phase in which a new, overall mode of regulation is gradually formulated (Aglietta, 1997; Boyer, 2013; Orléan, 2009).

Both in the past phase of globalization and emerging one, entrepreneurship and the deriving innovation lie at the center of this global accumulation status quo. The entrepreneurial innovation constitutes a dynamic phenomenon that reshapes the socioeconomic reality constantly, especially now when all spatial systems and socioeconomic organizations are being increasingly bound together. In today's age of the fourth industrial revolution (Schwab, 2016), knowledge is being understood as the crucial factor for socioeconomic

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development. To this end, the academic debate and policy practice seem to acknowledge progressively that robust and knowledge creating entrepreneurship strengthening policies are catalytic for the growth of the firms and, therefore, of the socioeconomic system as a whole (Apostolopoulos, Al-Dajani, Holt, Jones and Newbery, 2018; Bosma, Content, Sanders and Stam, 2018). In other words, entrepreneurship support mechanisms can favor institutional development if perceived as a structural pillar of modern economic policy (Liargovas, Apostolopoulos, Pappas and Kakouris, 2017).

Concerning the institutional environment, one approach that seems capable of interpreting the evolution of the qualitative characteristics of different economic policies is the analysis of different ontological levels (Serpa and Ferreira, 2019). This analysis considers the micro-level of individuals and firms, the meso-level of localities and agglomerations of firms, the macro-level of economic aggregations, and the macro-level of social changes. With this multilevel approach, this chapter attempts to propose a conceptual framework for fostering entrepreneurship in the form of a multilevel "competitiveness web." We aim to identify whether there are converging or divergent policy practices to strengthen entrepreneurship under this multilevel perspective, exploring the economies of the European South (Pal, 2005).

In particular, the European South constitutes a special case of "a multi-speed Europe," where different groups of member-states differ in institutional and developmental terms (Apostolopoulos and Liargovas, 2018). More precisely, this "variable geometry" at the European level is a condition of differentiated integration in the EU, which is, of course, not a new phenomenon (Pisani-Ferry, Sapir and Wolff, 2012; Stubb, 1996). For example, since its inception, the Economic and Monetary Union (EMU) constituted a differentiated integration in terms of the Monetary Union (member-states belonging in the Eurozone and member-states under divergence).

In terms of methodology, we will proceed with a general overview of the literature by aiming to construct and suggest a new conceptual framework. We will attempt to compose the different perspectives by creating a new theoretical filter and present examples from the practical experience by using this analytical prism.

The following steps of the paper reflect the research design:

1. Initially, we will explore recent theoretical approaches to the issue of entrepreneurship support policies.
2. Then, we will present an integrated concept of entrepreneurship and competitiveness policy in the form of a "competitiveness web" that takes into account all the macro, meso and micro levels of the socioeconomic space.
3. Subsequently, we will analyze recent developments in the field of entrepreneurship support policies of the countries of the European South under the macro-meso-micro perspective by trying to determine whether these countries and different socioeconomic spaces have structural competitive weaknesses.
4. Finally, we will conclude by discussing the implications and future research directions.

Literature review: Entrepreneurship enhancement policy and an integrated macro-meso-micro analytical counterproposal

Entrepreneurship enhancement policy includes measures that can increase the innovativeness of entrepreneurial activity and create an environment that encourages people to become entrepreneurs (Lundström and Stevenson, 2005). These set of policies include the aspect of individuality since entrepreneurship strengthening policy can provide the necessary background to turn a "simple man" into an entrepreneur, by fostering an environment favorable of new knowledge (Link, 2007). According to Audretsch and Beckmann (2007), entrepreneurship enhancement policies create a favorable framework for the commercialization of new ideas.

Entrepreneurship support policies also take on different structural dimensions and characteristics, depending on the country that implements them. For example, entrepreneurship policies include measures that aim at the micro-level, incentivizing entrepreneurial culture through the training and management skills of entrepreneurs, or may have a more horizontal macro-origin by providing state aid for general usage innovations and a more general improvement of the regulatory framework (Castaño-Martínez, Méndez-Picazo and Galindo-Martín, 2015). At the macro-level of government policy, governments must build an overall development vision, plan strategies, mobilize players and provide resources, in a way similar to policies targeting the micro-level of the firm (Kantis, Ishida and Komori, 2002).

From a synthesizing and multilevel perspective, the strategies, "players" and entrepreneurial resources can belong to different socioeconomic levels, while the "meso-environment" is an analytical category

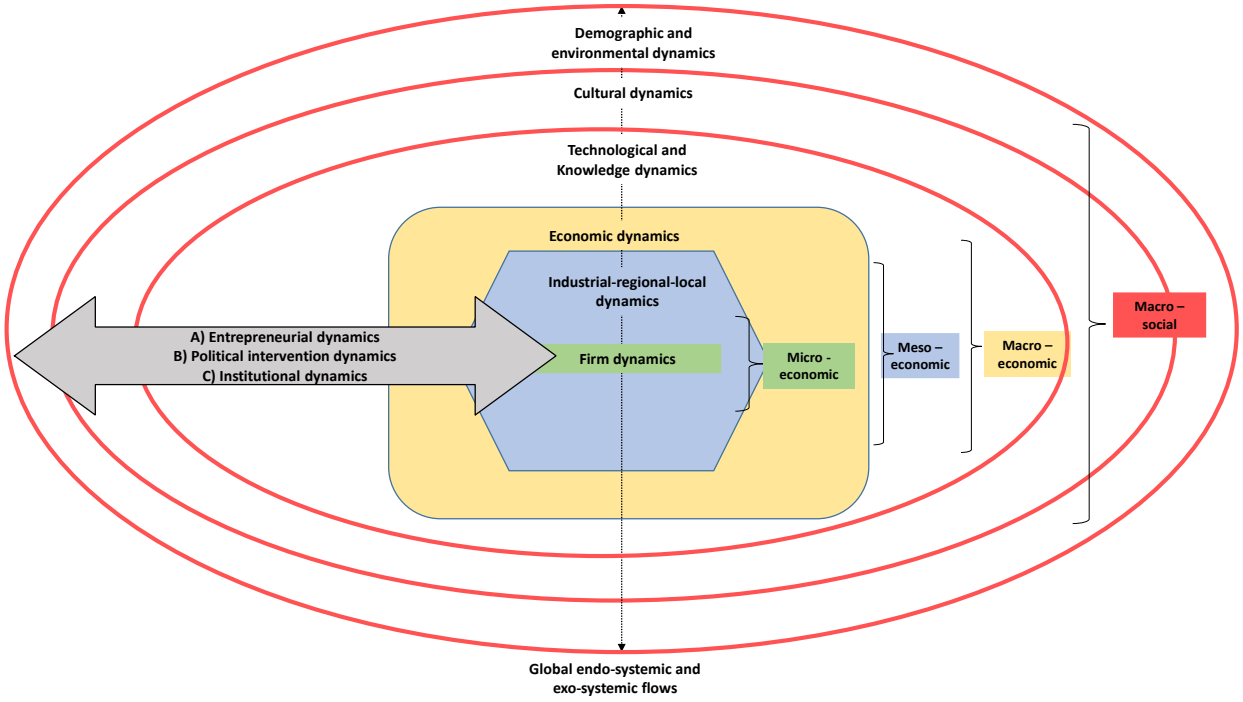
between the macro and the micro-levels of policy analysis (Cornia, Jolly and Stewart, 1987). According to Zezza and Llambí (2002), the meso-level is an integrated view of market mechanisms and administrative procedures that affect the micro-macro levels back and forth. Most public policy programs result from a macro-level design that converts ultimately into various goals and values by individuals at the micro-level. However, the local meso-level, where local actors and innovations affect the activities of the macro-micro level, is mostly absent (Virtanen and Uusikylä, 2004). According to Autio (2016), a government can engage in the meso-micro level in fostering entrepreneurship by promoting networking activities between different firms and investors, providing low-cost office space, training and consulting services, tax breaks and privileged access to government contracts, and enhancing the capacities of new ventures to innovate through direct interventions.

Mirzanti, Simatupang and Larso (2015) understand entrepreneurship strengthening policies on three distinct levels. The macro-level includes entrepreneurship education, infrastructure relating to entrepreneurship such as loan services or access to the internet, and entrepreneurial culture. The meso-level deals with administrative burden including all programs related to registration systems, entry/exit barriers, export/import regulations, investment and business procedures, incentives for specific groups relating to technology transfer, technology commercialization, and entrepreneurial incentives that include all programs related to labor market regulation, business taxes, and fiscal incentives. Lastly, the policy content at the micro-level includes entrepreneurship skills (such as training programs), opportunities through access to finance or programs related to market access, and motivation that can be caused by programs related to accelerators or incubators or mentorship.

In an integrated macro-meso-micro competitiveness and entrepreneurship policy framework, the socioeconomic system is being understood to unfold in an evolutionary multilevel process. That is, in the evolutionary interpretation, the historical background that incubated the particular manifestation at present is always a significant determinant creating specific developmental trajectories for the different factors of action (Nelson *et al*., 2018). From a converging perspective (Vlados and Katimertzopoulos, 2018), the micro-level corresponds to the stimulation of the locally operating business entities, the meso-level to the local productive socioeconomic "grid" and the macro-level to the overall attractiveness of the socioeconomic space that host new investments. The synthesis of the three levels corresponds to a multi-level competitiveness and entrepreneurship enhancement policy. According to Vlados (2019b), the multilevel socioeconomic system resembles a "competitiveness web" where all subsystems interact with each other dynamically (Figure 1).

[Figure 1 about here]

Figure 1: The competitiveness web.

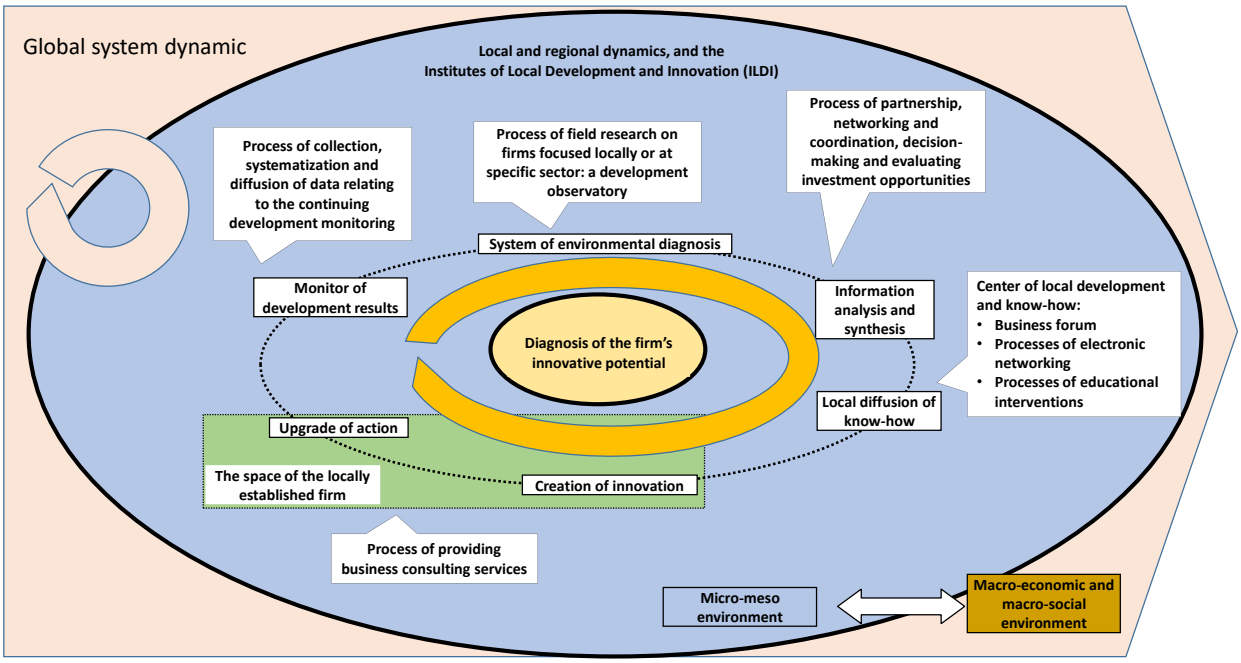


In the multilevel synthesis of the competitiveness web, all levels of space are in a structural correlation (Dopfer, 2011; Peneder, 2017). Any change in the macro-meso-micro web affects and transforms all levels since they are interconnected. The three structural spheres of the system are always the dynamics of entrepreneurship and the profit incentive that governs business operations, the political intervention that regulates different levels of social symbiosis and economic relationships, and the institutional dynamics that indicate the relative stability of specific rules and norms in the progress of a socioeconomic system. These three dynamic dimensions interact and co-evolve as active agents of readjustment of each socioeconomic system at every level of spatial analysis. Finally, global endo-systemic and exo-systemic flows, such as globalized sectors of economic activity, give the competitiveness web a character of "permanent disruption."

This competitiveness web is, in fact, an attempt to capture the entire socioeconomic system and the interactions between its partial elements. A vital feature of this formation is that all levels of space are in a constant "co-opetitive" relationship—competition and cooperation at the same time (Brandenburger and Nalebuff, 1996). At the level of articulating entrepreneurship strengthening policies, these usually start at the meso-micro firm level of training, education, mentoring and consulting. Many policies today aim at creating innovative business agglomerations, mainly in the form of clusters, which include local firms that share common characteristics, particularly in terms of their industrial focus (Lazzeretti, Sedita and Caloffi, 2014). Moreover, these policies may target more inter-sectoral forms, such as business ecosystems that constitute value networks built around mostly some "keystone species" (Iansiti and Levien, 2004). In any case, the advancement of innovation at the meso-micro level requires, besides a conducive business environment, targeted political intervention in the "cellular" innovation created in the internal "organs" of the firm (Abell, Felin and Foss, 2008). One such meso-micro policy is the Institutes of Local Development and Innovation (Figure 2).

[Figure 2 about here]

Figure 2: An Institute of Local Development and Innovation (ILDI), according to Vlados (2016)



According to Vlados (2016), who focuses on the case of Greece, this local mechanism can be a policy that fosters entrepreneurship at the meso-micro level. This mechanism could begin by diagnosing the firm's innovative potential that lies at the center of the local-regional system and then could operate in a cycle of six consecutive steps. This cycle includes a system of environmental diagnosis, followed by information analysis and synthesis, local diffusion of expertise, creation of innovation, upgrade of action, and monitoring of development results. Beyond its centrally designed mechanism, this intermediate organization should aim to interconnect any actors capable of enhancing the prospects of innovation of the local system.

A multilevel political intervention to boost entrepreneurship that, most often, is "diagonal" rather than just vertical or horizontal, must not aim at subsidizing "national champions" in specific industries (European Commission, 2011), but should encourage and support change management and innovation at all levels (Torfing, Peters, Pierre and Sørensen, 2012; Vlados and Chatzinikolaou, 2019). Elements of such a comprehensive policy can exist at both the macro-economic and macro-social levels. That is, at the macro-level are those policies that shape the so-called business environment or climate and are usually a priority for ministries other than those for development or innovation national ministries. Usually, the Ministry of Finance is responsible for macro-economic policies on taxation and interest rates, while any other policy indirectly touching the business environment is one of the macro-social factors. Macro-social policies can include regulations such as the legislation of the natural environmental management context, the framework of education and training, and the cultural subsystem empowerment, renovation, and valorization put forward by different ministries, such as the "Ministry of Education," the "Ministry of Energy," or the "Ministry of Culture."

Overall, the issue of development/underdevelopment crosses the entrepreneurship of socioeconomic systems transversely. In this context, the three macro-meso-micro levels are, in fact, an attempt to develop an understanding of the different levels involved in socioeconomic development, both individually and in composition (Dopfer, Foster and Potts, 2004). However, to what extent are there entrepreneurship enhancement policies implemented at a micro-level? What meso-micro and macro-economic and macro-social policies exist mostly? Do developed countries implement an integrated macro-meso-micro policy framework to support entrepreneurship? The next section attempts to answer these questions by taking as a case study entrepreneurship support policies in countries of the European South, which are experiencing structural issues of competitiveness.

Recent policy practices to support entrepreneurship in the European South: A macro-meso-micro theoretical evaluation

European South countries have not yet recovered in terms of economic growth following the shock of 2008-2009 (Andreou, Andrikopoulos and Nastopoulos, 2017; Elert, Henrekson and Sanders, 2019; McCann and Ortega-Argilés, 2016). According to the European Commission (2018), Croatia, Cyprus, Greece, Italy and Portugal are experiencing significant growth retardation in the value-added and employment of small and medium-sized enterprises, although between 2013 and 2017 value-added and employment of SMEs in EU-28 increased by 15.1% and 7.1% respectively.

Another issue that seems to affect these countries—mainly Greece and Italy and, to a lesser extent, Spain and Portugal—concerns the implementation of the legislation and, more generally, the rule of law (Elert, Henrekson and Stenkula, 2017). More profoundly, both the business culture and the value that societies of these countries attach to entrepreneurship appear to be problematic compared to other EU member-states (Fernández-Serrano, Berbegal, Velasco and Expósito, 2018).

One study outlining policies to strengthen the business environment, mainly from a "horizontal" perspective (Warwick, 2013), is the "Doing Business" report by the World Bank. The categories or policy areas that World Bank uses to classify and rate the different environments are the following: paying taxes, employing workers/labor market regulation, registering property, resolving insolvency, dealing across construction permits, enforcing contracts, getting electricity, getting credit, protecting minority investors, and starting a business. Doing Business focuses mainly on the macro-economic and macro-social levels, meaning that it does not take into account meso-micro-level elements. Table 1 presents the reforms that European South countries implemented recently by identifying the available data for these countries from the last three Doing Business reports.

Table 1: Recent reforms to improve the business environment in the countries of the European South

Croatia	Protecting minority investors: "*Croatia strengthened minority investor protections by requiring detailed internal disclosure of conflicts of interest by directors*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 174) Registering property: "*Croatia made it less costly to transfer property by lowering the real estate transfer tax*." (World Bank, 2018, p. 129) Registering property: "*Croatia made transferring property more efficient by digitizing its land registry*." (World Bank, 2019, p. 137)
Cyprus	Starting a business: "*Cyprus made starting a business easier by merging the procedures to register for taxes and VAT, and making company name search and reservation faster*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 174) Paying taxes: "*Cyprus made paying taxes easier by introducing improvements to its internal processes and to the electronic tax filing system. Cyprus also made paying taxes less costly by increasing the discount rate applied on immovable property tax*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 174) Employing workers: "*Cyprus amended its legislation to allow shops and supermarkets to operate seven days a week*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 174) Protecting minority investors: "*Cyprus strengthened minority investor protections by increasing disclosure of related-party transactions and strengthening shareholders' rights and role in major corporate decisions*." (World Bank, 2019, p. 138) Paying taxes: "*Cyprus made paying taxes easier by abolishing the immovable property tax, discontinuing the special contribution for private sector employees, private sector pensioners and self-employed individuals, introducing an online system for filing value added tax returns and value added tax refund claims and reducing the sewerage duty tax rates*." (World Bank, 2019, p. 138)
Greece	Enforcing contracts: "*Greece made enforcing contracts easier by amending its rules of civil procedure to introduce tighter rules on adjournments, impose deadlines for key court events and limit the recourses that can be lodged during enforcement proceedings*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 175) Starting a business: "*Greece made starting a business easier by creating a unified social security institution*." (World Bank, 2018, p. 131) Dealing with construction permits: "*Greece streamlined its construction permitting process as building owners must now use their in-house engineer for the intermediate inspection, as opposed to the municipality*." (World Bank, 2019, p. 140)
Italy	Paying taxes: "*Italy made paying taxes easier by allowing full cost of labor to be deductible for regional tax on productive activities (IRAP) purposes, as well as updating coefficients used for calculation of tax on real estate (IMU) and municipal service tax (TASI). Furthermore, the electronic system for preparing and paying labor taxes was improved*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 177) Getting electricity: "*Italy made getting electricity easier by streamlining the application process and reducing the time for the external works and meter installation*." (World Bank, 2018, p. 132)

	Paying taxes: "*Italy made paying taxes less costly by temporarily exempting employers from social security contributions. Italy also made paying taxes easier by abolishing the Comunicazione dati IVA (value added tax communication form)*." (World Bank, 2018, p. 132)
Portugal	Getting electricity: "*Portugal made getting an electricity connection faster by reducing the time required to approve electrical connection requests.*" (World Bank, 2017, p. 182) Paying taxes: "*Portugal made paying taxes easier and less costly by using better accounting software and enhancing the online filing system of taxes and decreasing the corporate income tax rate*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 182) Labor market regulation: "*Portugal reduced the maximum duration of fixed-term contracts*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 182)
Spain	Paying taxes: "*Spain made paying taxes less costly by reducing the property tax rate, vehicle tax rate, tax on property transfer, and abolishing the environmental fee. Spain made paying taxes easier by introducing a new electronic system for filing social security contributions*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 184) Enforcing contracts: "*Spain made enforcing contracts easier by introducing a mandatory electronic filing system for court users*." (World Bank, 2017, p. 184) Enforcing contracts: "*Spain made enforcing contracts easier by reducing court fees for filing a claim*." (World Bank, 2018, p. 138)

There seem to be a plethora of mostly macro-economic and macro-social reforms in the countries of the European South. Moreover, these examples of horizontal "macro-reforms" confirm the approach that different ministries can participate equally in articulating entrepreneurship and competitiveness policies by implementing different regulations starting from specific labor, construction and other laws. To what extent, however, do meso-micro-level policies emerge in the European South to promote innovation at the center of the socioeconomic system?

One study for identifying the level of entrepreneurship development is the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM). GEM classifies different countries according to "entrepreneurial framework conditions" by using "national experts" surveys. It names these factors "entrepreneurial framework conditions" and classifies them from insufficient (one point) to sufficient (five points). These entrepreneurial framework conditions are the following: entrepreneurial finance, governmental policies: support and relevance, governmental policies: taxes and bureaucracy, government entrepreneurship programs, entrepreneurial education at school stage, entrepreneurial education at the post-school stage, R&D transfer, commercial and legal infrastructure, internal market dynamics, internal market burdens or entry regulation, physical infrastructure, cultural and social norms (Bosma and Kelley, 2019).

Although it does not classify the level of entrepreneurship and competitiveness of different countries in an explicit macro-meso-micro socioeconomic way, the conclusions of the study are useful under this macro-meso-micro methodological "filter." Table 2 presents some of the general directions that European South countries have been pursuing recently to support their entrepreneurship by using recent studies by the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor.

Table 2: Entrepreneurship in the European South through recent studies

Croatia	"*In 2018, the government introduced vouchers which will support collaboration between businesses and research institutions. New regulatory changes prepared in 2018 will decrease the burden for entering the market for different products and services in the future*." (Bosma and Kelley, 2019, p. 75)
Cyprus	Cyprus "*recently passed enhanced tax incentives for innovative small and medium-sized enterprises as well as for startups are expected to attract multinational entrepreneurs seeking to be in the European, Middle-East and Africa region*." (Bosma and Kelley, 2019, p. 76)
Greece	In August 2018, "*an eight-year cycle of three successive programs of economic support and adjustment programs completed. A significant amount of adjustment and rebalancing in the economy has been achieved, exports and investments have also increased, although domestic financing conditions remain very weak*." (Bosma and Kelley, 2019, p. 80)
Italy	Italy has a "*generous welfare system. This is expected to become even more generous with the introduction of the citizenship income plan, proposed by the Five Star Movement, the populist political party that won the latest polls*." (Bosma and Kelley, 2019, p. 87)
Portugal	National experts consider national culture in Portugal as poorly oriented towards entrepreneurship and notice a lack of stimulating individual success. However, the existence of science parks, technology, and business incubators and various support programs available to new companies is a favorable point in Portugal's development. Moreover, national experts consider the availability of government subsidies as the main factor for promoting entrepreneurial activity in terms of financing (Global Entrepreneurship Monitor, 2013).

Spain	"*On average, jobs created in the last 12 months by new firms have increased by 118%. Likewise, jobs generated by established firms have increased by 70% despite stagnant entrepreneurial activity, the impact of entrepreneurship on job creation and its contribution to the recovery of the economy is increasing*." (Bosma and Kelley, 2019, p. 104)

To a large extent, these policies (or the general business climate) in the European South should be moving probably in an analogous direction to meso-micro-level policies that Croatia and Cyprus seem to implement with partnerships between firms and research institutes and provisions of tax incentives for innovative small and medium-sized enterprises. Concerning Greece, this country appears to be in a transitional phase, Portugal supports some significant innovation infrastructures such as science parks, while Spain is also gradually moving to improve the competitiveness of its economy.

To see what a meso-micro-level approach to enhancing "cellular" innovation and entrepreneurship might look like, the conclusions of the latest GEM report on Germany are useful. In particular, "*governments at each level (federal, federal states, local) have 'discovered' new firms started by young people as an important target group of their regional, educational, technology, economic and innovation policies. This may have contributed to a considerable improvement of the entrepreneurial climate, particularly among young citizens*" (Bosma and Kelley, 2019, p. 79). Therefore, significant differences in the level of policy conception at the meso-micro level exist, mainly between the more competitive Germany as compared to the European South. Strengthening the meso-micro level seems to lead to innovation in the overall socioeconomic system. This juxtaposition between Germany and the European South reinforces the interpretative power of the macro-meso-micro entrepreneurship enhancement policy scheme, given that Germany is today one of the leading countries in institutional and economic terms (Schoeller, 2019).

Countries of the European South demonstrate, as it seems, competitiveness insufficiencies not created solely by some dependence relations of the Center upon the South where, allegedly, in a neo-Marxist perspective (Vlados, 2019a), the influence of the center is so significant that it does not allow the dependent countries to develop. Today, the articulation of meso-micro-level policies seems to be a priority for a growing number of socioeconomic systems, regardless of dependency relationships or previous structural underdevelopment, that is, even for developing countries all around the world (Altaf, Hassan and Batool, 2019).

Undoubtedly, macro-social factors, such as business culture in the countries of the European South, seem to play a decisive role, although meso-micro-level political practices are indeed a priority for the most competitive countries nowadays. In the ongoing fourth industrial revolution, the flows between different socioeconomic organizations and systems are increasingly subversive. Therefore, successful firms develop their human resources through continuing and systematic training to improve the skills of their employees by nurturing the elements of initiative and creativity. In this context, innovative success or failure also determines the developmental prospects of their hosting socioeconomic systems.

A new entrepreneurship strengthening policy should be undoubtedly multilevel, as all the macro-meso-micro levels of the socioeconomic system constitute mutual developmental forces. Most of the time, however, both at the level of countries with actual developmental and competitiveness insufficiencies (such as the countries of the European South) and at the level of conceptualizing the impact of these policies (see, for example, the GEM and Doing Business reports), an integrated macro-meso-micro perspective seems to be absent. To this end, the policy framework proposed in this chapter in the form of a multilevel "competitiveness web" that takes into account all levels of the socio-economic space by focusing on meso-micro-level policies seems to be a new concept of policy practice that can be incorporated at different socioeconomic systems.

Concluding remarks

This chapter attempted a repositioning of the contemporary discourse on the issue of policies to support entrepreneurship. It presented entrepreneurship and innovation as the most critical developmental factors for all socioeconomic systems, while noted that—especially at a time when the global economy is going through a phase of profound crisis and restructuring—policies to boost entrepreneurship can turn a country more or less competitive.

By focusing on examples of policies in the countries of the European South, we concluded that a reason for their relative developmental hysteresis is their fragmentary approach to the issue of strengthening their entrepreneurship potential. As a result, we found that an integrated macro-meso-micro perspective is mostly absent from the articulation of entrepreneurship enhancement policies in these countries.

The context of competitiveness web, in which the structured parts of the socioeconomic system are composed, is a theoretical filter that could be used as a future research direction. Since the competitiveness web framework explores which policies correspond to the different levels where the socioeconomic actors compete (macro, meso, or micro), then this could be a diagnostic mechanism to investigate and determine the competitiveness conditions and dynamics of the entire socioeconomic system through the assembly of a competitiveness index. This index could measure and correlate the number of entrepreneurship support policies at each level by also taking into account quantitative and qualitative comparative data for different socioeconomic spheres and spaces. In this way, it could serve as a tool for ameliorating the interventional practices for strengthening entrepreneurship in a benchmarking logic.

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